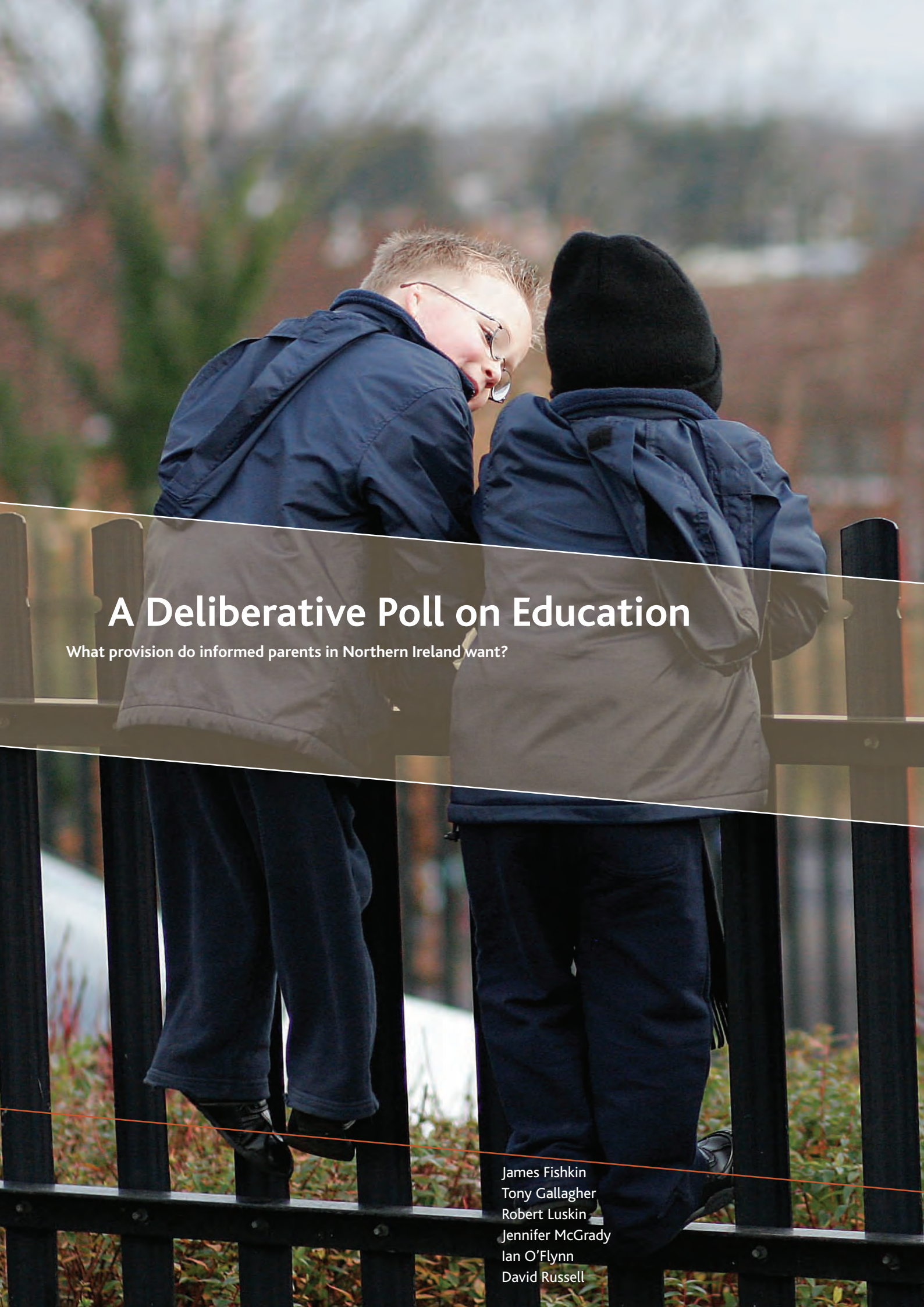


A photograph of two young children, a boy and a girl, standing behind a black metal fence. The boy on the left is wearing glasses and a blue jacket, looking towards the girl. The girl on the right is wearing a black beanie and a blue jacket, looking away. The background is a blurred residential area with trees and houses. A semi-transparent white banner is overlaid across the middle of the image, containing the title and subtitle.

A Deliberative Poll on Education

What provision do informed parents in Northern Ireland want?

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What is a Deliberative Poll¹?

The public is often uninformed about key policy issues and decisions made by governments in their name. This may be because ordinary people are simply disinterested in politics. But it may also be because they do not have an adequate opportunity to learn about the issues or a genuine opportunity to influence the decisions that result. Of course, there are times when governments and politicians pay a great deal of attention to the views and opinions of the public and even shape their policies accordingly. This is especially the case in the run up to an election or referendum. At such times, conventional opinion polls are often used to gauge the mood of the general population. But since the findings of such polls tend to

represent little more than surface impressions of sound bites and headlines, politicians often treat them as a mechanism for winning votes rather than a resource for helping to determine what decisions they should make.

In contrast to a poll of the conventional sort, a Deliberative Poll seeks to reveal what the public would think if its members had the opportunity to learn about a given policy issue and to present their conclusions to decision makers. To begin with, a random selection of people is asked to fill out a questionnaire on the issue, usually through face-to-face interviews or by telephone. Having taken this poll, they are then invited to gather

together for a day or weekend of deliberations. Those who accept this invitation are sent carefully balanced briefing materials, created in consultation with key stakeholders and experts, which explain the advantages and disadvantages of the various policy options that they will be discussing.

Organisers of a Deliberative Poll go to great lengths to ensure that discussions will take place in a safe, shared and constructive environment. To begin with, the members of the sample are randomly assigned to small groups to discuss the briefing materials. Trained facilitators are on hand to clarify any ambiguities and to ensure that each group member has a chance to ask questions and to have



their views and opinions heard. The facilitators also ensure that all contributions to the discussions are treated with respect. After about an hour and a half, each small group decides on a number of questions about the policy options they have been discussing. After a break for refreshments, the entire sample then meets in plenary in order to put its questions to a balanced panel of experts which may include political leaders. The process (small group discussions followed by a plenary session) is then repeated as the sample continues to work its way through the briefing materials.

At the end of the day, the sample is polled once again, using the same

questionnaire they took at home. Pre-and post-deliberation results are then collated and statistically assessed. Deliberative Polls consistently produce marked shifts in opinion. Crucially, these changes in opinion represent the conclusions members of the public would reach, if they had the opportunity to become more informed and more engaged by the issues. The key desiderata for a Deliberative Poll are that the sample be representative and that the participants become more informed. We believe the Omagh project satisfied both criteria. Hence, we believe, the resulting opinions merit serious consideration by policy makers. ■

Omagh

In January 2007 a collaborative research team, led by Newcastle University and including the Centre for Deliberative Democracy at Stanford University and the School of Education at Queen's University Belfast, conducted a Deliberative Poll in Omagh. The aim of the project was to gauge the opinion of parents of school-aged children about education provision. This was the first Deliberative Poll to be held in Northern Ireland.

Omagh was chosen as a suitable geographical location for the poll because it fitted a number of essential criteria:

1. it typifies much of Northern Ireland in that it has a large market town with a recognised rural hinterland
2. it has a mixed population of Catholics and Protestants
3. it has both primary and post-primary schools representing the majority of school types—Controlled, Voluntary, Maintained, Integrated, Irish Medium, Co-ed and Single-sex, and Grammar)
4. the schools are a variety of sizes—the largest primary school has almost 500 pupils, while there are a number of quite small rural schools; among the post-primary schools, some have fewer than 200 pupils whereas others have almost 1,000 pupils
5. the area has been subject to a demographic downturn—the number of young people entering schools has fallen by about 10 per cent over a five year period; more generally, pupil projections from the Department of Education suggest that the number of pupils in schools will continue to decline for a considerable period, which in turn means that some rationalisation of schools is likely to occur in the coming years.

Throughout January, the market research company Ipsos-Mori carried



out 565 door-to-door interviews across the Omagh District Council area. Addresses were selected at random, using the postal address file; within each household the parent interviewed was randomly chosen on the basis of the next birthday rule (i.e., the parent who had the next birthday was selected for interview).

Of the sample, 68% considered themselves to be Catholic or had a Catholic background, while 27.8% considered themselves to be Protestant or had a Protestant background (4.2% had an 'other' religious background or did not respond to the question). This closely parallels the religious composition of

Omagh as documented in the 2001 Northern Ireland Census, which found that 68.22% of Omagh residents were Catholic or had a Catholic background, while 29.45% were Protestant or had a Protestant background.²

25.7% of the sample considered themselves to be nationalist in their political orientation, while 11.7% considered themselves to be unionist. 57.5% of the sample said they were 'neither,' and 5.1% said they were 'other' or did not respond to the question. The high percentage of participants indicating that they were neither nationalist nor unionist is unlikely to be a true reflection of

identity patterns, rather it probably reflects both the sensitivity and complexity of this question and a corresponding unwillingness by the participants to disclose information, or a failure of the options to accurately capture personal preferences.

The parents in the sample had an average of 2.03 children each, with an average of 1.02 children attending primary school and 1.01 children attending post-primary school. The table followings shows the percentage of respondents who had at least one child in each school type:

² Northern Ireland Census 2001 Key Statistics for Settlements. Available at http://www.nisra.new.nisra.gov.uk/Census/Census2001Output/KeyStatistics/ks_settlements.html

SCHOOL TYPE	PRE-DELIBERATION SAMPLE: Percentage with at least one child in the following school types (N=565)
Catholic primary	43.2%
Controlled primary	16.1%
Integrated primary	3.5%
Special primary	1.4%
Irish-medium primary	0.7%
Controlled secondary	11.0%
Catholic secondary	24.6%
Controlled grammar	10.8%
Catholic grammar	18.4%
Integrated secondary	8.8%
Irish-medium secondary	0.4%
Special secondary	0.5%
Fermanagh college	0.2%

All the members of the sample were invited to attend the Deliberative Poll event at Omagh College of Further and Higher Education on 27th January, at which they would have an opportunity to discuss education with other parents and to put any questions they might have to senior education officials. 250 parents said 'yes' or 'maybe' to the invitation. In the week before the event, the parents received briefing materials in the post that outlined various options for delivering education, and some advantages and disadvantages associated with each. These briefing materials had been drafted in

consultation with the management interests of schools. The organisations involved in this process were:

1. Department of Education
2. Council for Catholic Maintained Schools
3. Northern Ireland Council for Integrated Education
4. Western Education and Library Board
5. Comhairle Na Gaelscolaíochta
6. Trustees of the Christian Brothers
7. Trustees of Loreto Convent.

127 parents participated in the event

at Omagh College.³ Of those participating 62.8% considered themselves to be Catholic or had a Catholic background, while 33.9% considered themselves to be Protestant or had a Protestant background (3.3% had an 'other' religious background or did not respond to the question).

25.6% of the sample considered themselves to be nationalist in their political orientation, while 15.7% considered themselves to be unionist. 56.2% of the sample said they were 'neither,' and 2.5% said they were 'other' or did not respond to the question. Once again, the high percentage of participants indicating that they were neither nationalist nor unionist is unlikely to be a true reflection of identity patterns, rather it probably reflects both the sensitivity and complexity of this question and a corresponding unwillingness by the participants to disclose information, or a failure of the options to accurately capture personal preferences.

The parents who attended the Omagh event had an average of 2.14 children each, with an average of 0.88 children attending primary school and 1.27 children attending post-primary school. The table following shows the percentage of respondents who had at least one child in each school type:

SCHOOL TYPE	POST-DELIBERATION SAMPLE: Percentage with at least one child in the following school types (N=121)
Catholic primary	31.4%
Controlled primary	19.0%
Integrated primary	3.3%
Special primary	1.7%
Irish-medium primary	0.8%
Controlled secondary	14.0%
Catholic secondary	37.2%
Controlled grammar	11.6%
Catholic grammar	19.0%
Integrated secondary	11.6%
Irish-medium secondary	0.0%
Special secondary	0.8%
Fermanagh college	0.0%

questions that sought to measure the impact of deliberation).

Parts of this event were broadcast by BBC Northern Ireland, as a 'Hearts and Minds' special, on 3rd February 2007. It was also covered by local, national and international press, ensuring that the findings of the poll—specifically, the informed opinions of a random sample of parents from the Omagh area—would have an increased chance to shape education policy and generate wider public discussion. ■

The parents registered for the event between 8.30am and 9am and were randomly assigned to small groups of approximately 10 people each.

At 9.30am the small groups began discussing the briefing materials with guidance from trained facilitators. The discussions ended at 11am, with each group agreeing on two questions that they wished to ask during the following plenary session. To answer the questions, each of the management interests involved during the consultation on the content of the briefing material was represented on the plenary expert panel. The Northern Ireland

Community Relations Council was also represented as an interest group external to education.

The plenary session was independently chaired and the representatives of the management interests were encouraged to provide a concise response to the parents' questions. At 12.45pm, there was a break for lunch. In the afternoon, small group discussions were again followed by a plenary. The day ended at 5.15pm when 121 parents completed the same questionnaire that they had completed earlier in the month (with the addition of some

The briefing materials

Two of the biggest threats to good deliberation are limited information and skewed information. If people have limited information, the conclusions that they reach will not be as informed as they might otherwise have been. If information is skewed in one direction, the conclusions that they reach may be correspondingly loaded or unbalanced. Under such conditions, we have no choice but to question the status of the deliberative process and its findings.

The Deliberative Polling team went to great lengths to ensure that parents would be presented with as complete and balanced a picture of education provision as possible. In consultation with key educational stakeholders, the project team carefully compiled a briefing document laying out some of

the advantages and disadvantages of the main options. As part of this process, the key stakeholders were given the opportunity to read the briefing document in draft form and to propose revisions. Those who availed of this opportunity were then asked to approve a revised document, which in turn helped to lend authority and legitimacy to the process as a whole.

Before turning to the actual content of the document, one point, of central importance to this report, should be stressed. The aim of a Deliberative Poll is to solicit the informed views of the public—that is, to discover what the public would think if they had the chance to really consider the issues. Crucially, Deliberative Polling does not push any particular policy position or start with 'right answers' in mind.

On the contrary, it is left to participants to think and decide for themselves. The briefing document that was sent to parents was constructed with this basic principle in mind.

Turning, then, to the document itself, parents were first informed that 'Education in Northern Ireland is changing'. In particular, the document began by outlining the two main reasons why change was inevitable, namely the statutory obligation to provide the new 'entitlement framework' in post primary schools, and more generally, the problem of falling pupil numbers. It then explained that change could take many different forms, and proposed to discuss the advantages and disadvantages of those forms by reference to four broad themes or dimensions:



1. Curriculum: the curriculum, or range of subjects, which each school directly teaches.

2. School collaboration: the extent to which (and the ways in which) schools collaborate with other schools mainly to provide the 'entitlement framework'.

3. Denominational collaboration: the extent to which schools from different religious traditions work together.

4. Age-grouping for schools: the organisation of schools in relation to the age of the pupils that they take.



(1) *Curriculum:* Although all schools in Omagh are legally required to deliver a common statutory curriculum, in practice grammar schools tend to give a more focused academic emphasis to their curriculum. Many of the secondary schools also include academic streams for some of their pupils, but they usually have to provide a curriculum which meets the needs of pupils with a much wider range of abilities.

As the briefing document made clear, there are a number of ways in which schools might change in regard to the type of curriculum that they offer. First, some schools could continue to provide an academic emphasis to their curriculum, while others could continue to focus on technical/vocational subjects. While this option would provide a clear choice for parents and children, it

would force them to make an early choice of pathway. Secondly, some schools could specialise in certain subjects. This option would work well if all schools specialised, but it is unclear as to which schools would specialise in which subjects. Thirdly, all-ability schools could be developed, providing the same wide curriculum for all pupils. This option would guarantee all students a specific range of subjects, but it might result in a small number of very large schools.

(2) *School Collaboration:* Under government plans schools will collaborate to a greater extent in the future. It will, however, be up to schools and management interests to decide themselves how far they want to develop these arrangements.

Again, the briefing document presented parents with a range of

options along this dimension. First, a certain number of teachers from different schools could collaborate across schools. This option would be easy to implement, but might not help post-primary schools to deliver the new 'entitlement framework.' Secondly, two or more schools could agree to share the use of some specialist facility, such as a sports hall or science laboratory. Although this option would result in economic savings, it might favour schools located fairly closely to the facility in question. Thirdly, shared campuses or shared courses could be created, with each school retaining its distinctive identity. This option would make it easier to deliver the entitlement framework, but the briefing document made clear that it might result in children from rural areas travelling considerable distances.



(3) *Denominational collaboration:* As is the case across Northern Ireland, most schools in Omagh have either a predominately Protestant or a predominately Catholic pupil profile. Again, parents were presented with a number of options for change on this dimension.

First, current practices could remain largely as they are. Although this option would retain the traditional links between communities and schools, it may limit the scope for cross-sectoral collaboration and cross-community sharing. Secondly, jointly-managed schools could be created, encouraging greater sharing. However, in a context in which cultural distinctiveness is often viewed as extremely important, it is not clear whether this option would attract public support. Thirdly, it might be possible to establish

formally-integrated schools, in which all the partners, including the Churches and the other education providers, would have a right to play a role. Although this option would allow for rationalisation, it would remove the traditional role of the Churches in education.

(4) *Age-grouping for schools:* Most post-primary schools in Northern Ireland either take pupils aged 11-16 years or pupils aged 11-19 years. Once again, the briefing document offered a number of ways in which this particular dimension might change in the future.

First, although the present pattern could be retained, this option would probably require significant change in other areas in order to help schools deliver the 'entitlement framework.' Secondly, the school system could

change so that most schools would take pupils aged 11-16 years, with a small number of schools—probably some of the existing grammars—converting into Sixth Form Colleges for pupils aged 16-19 years. This would maximise choice, but it would also mean that most post-primary schools would lose their sixth-form students. Finally, schools could change either in to junior-high schools (11-14 years) or senior-high schools (11-19 years). This would allow many rural schools to remain open, while enabling other schools to specialise at senior-high level. But it would also mean that pupils would have to change schools and hence have their education disrupted. ■

The policy context

Deliberative Polling has been proven to engender mutual understanding and sensitivity to the greater public good. Empirical evidence from the numerous polls conducted by the Centre for Deliberative Democracy at Stanford University—in settings as diverse as the USA, UK, Australia, China and Greece, and covering issues as potentially divisive as crime, national security, constitutional status and the allocation of local resources—demonstrates that this methodology brings balance to discussions on issues pertaining to policy choices, and avoids the conflictual tendencies inherent in less structured community-auditing techniques.

The research team began from the assumption that a Deliberative Poll on education in Northern Ireland could inform government about the best means by which cross-sector collaboration and cross-community

sharing could be delivered. The process was designed to focus on the issue of sustainable schools in a changing education system with the aim of upholding the right of parental choice in a constructive and forward-looking way.

The report of the Independent Strategic Review of Education⁴ notes that Northern Ireland's education structures are based almost entirely on a principle of institutional independence. The Review further comments that the separation which exists within the present system is, 'to a greater or lesser extent, at a cost to learners' experiences and opportunities, to teachers and principals, to the efficient use of the schools estate, and to economic well-being, and the integration and health of our society more generally.' In order to bring about necessary reform, therefore, it is argued that

schools should be measured against three key standards:

1. the educational case—access for pupils to the full range of the curriculum (including the new entitlement framework), to high quality teaching, and to modern facilities
2. the social case—enhancing societal well-being by promoting a culture of tolerance, mutual understanding and inter-relationship through significant, purposeful and regular engagement and interaction in learning
3. the economic case—through cost-effective provision that gives good value for money.

Reconfiguring the schools estate in accordance with this agenda will require significant change in the planning process. At present, planning lacks co-ordination and consistency because individual education and library boards



and sectoral management interests tend to operate in isolation. The report of the Independent Strategic Review of Education recommends that future planning should be area-based, and that the Department of Education should develop quality indicators and other criteria to be used consistently, in conjunction with a sustainable schools policy so as to 'assess the appropriateness, quality and effectiveness of the educational provision in an area; the sufficiency, suitability and condition of the schools' accommodation and facilities; the nature and quality of the connection between the schools and the community; and the extent to which the provision reflects value for money.'

To ensure effective, efficient and participative procedures for area-based planning, it is further recommended that planning groups be created that are representative of

all the educational interests—presumably to include organisations such as the Council for Catholic Maintained Schools, Northern Ireland Council for Integrated Education, Comhairle Na Gaelscolaíochta, the Trustees of the Catholic Church, representatives of the grammar schools and the Transferors' Representative Council. Although these organisations will play their part in ascertaining the demand for provision of schools of particular types, and can bring such information into the planning process, it is argued that there is a case for consulting directly with the community on a set of possible options. For this sort of process to be successful it would need to be free from manipulation and exploitation to avoid politicking.

Deliberative Polling provides a methodology that can meet the requirements for a community

consultative process. It can engage the parents of school-aged children, or the public more generally, allow them to become better informed about proposed government policies, and allow them to voice their considered opinions in a safe, shared and constructive environment. Crucially, deliberation takes place under controlled conditions which aim to ensure that the process is free from manipulation and exploitation. The poll which took place in Omagh demonstrates how a community could be engaged in future area-based planning processes so as to play a constructive role in building common solutions to the shared challenge of developing schools that are fit for purpose. The results demonstrate the kinds of education provision informed parents want. ■

The results

The parents who participated in the Omagh Deliberative Poll were asked to complete a questionnaire that reflected the content of the briefing materials. In addition, participants were also asked to consider the issue of community relations. The aim here was to measure concepts such as perceptions of reasonableness and trust, how favourably parents felt towards members of the two main communities, and their attitudes towards mixing versus separation. Participants were asked whether they thought changes to the education

system would equally benefit children from both of the main communities—Catholic and Protestant. They were also asked whether greater mutual respect and understanding might result from mixed education and whether education is necessarily linked to economic prosperity. Finally, a number of questions sought to explore the level of knowledge that parents participating had concerning both the current education system and the changes being implemented or proposed by government.





Curriculum

Participants were asked to consider how schools deliver the common statutory curriculum and to take cognisance of the future changes to be implemented by the Department of Education. In particular, the briefing materials drew attention to the introduction of the 'entitlement framework' and the fact that all post-primary schools will in future be expected to provide a choice of at least 24 curriculum subjects, at least a third of which must be 'academic' and a third of which must be 'applied'. Participants were then asked to indicate if they would support, oppose, or, neither support nor oppose the following choices for schools in the Omagh area:

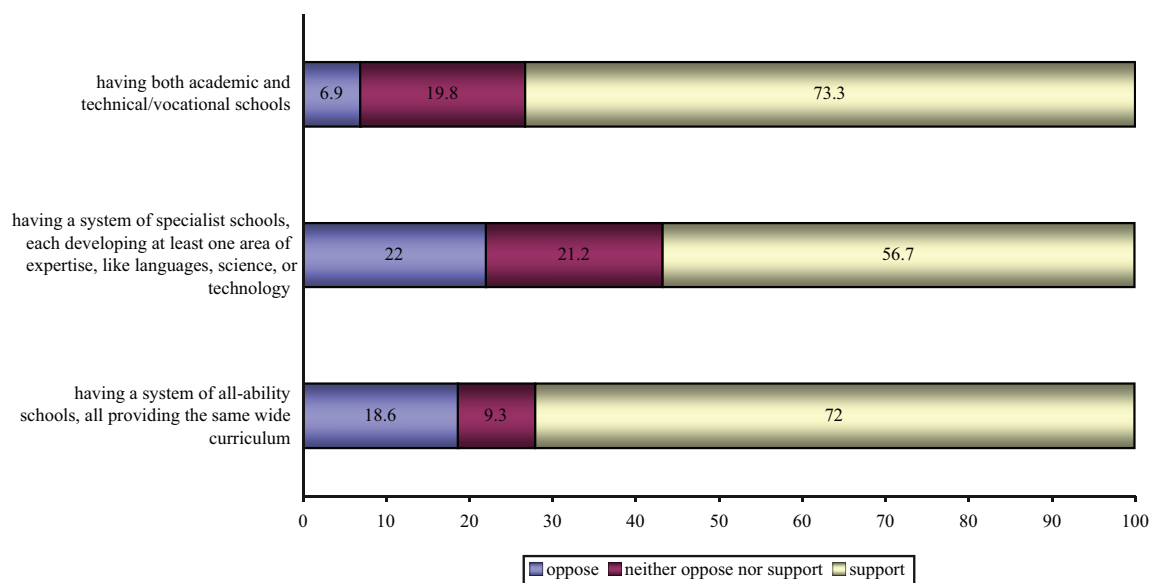
1. having both academic and technical/vocational schools;
2. having a system of specialist schools, each developing at least one area of expertise, like languages, science, or technology;
3. having a system of all-ability schools, all providing the same wide curriculum.

Pre-deliberation results (T1) and post-deliberation results (T2) did not show significant changes in the opinions of those taking part.

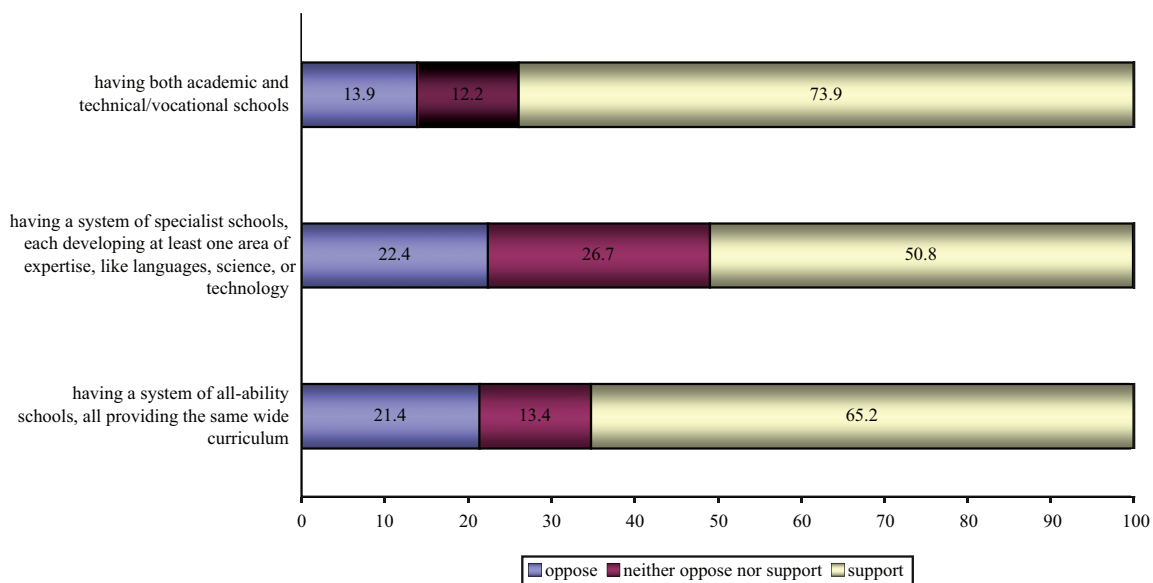
A substantive number of parents (73.3% T1 and 73.9% T2) supported having both academic and technical/vocational schools. A bare majority supported having a system of specialist schools (each developing at least one area of expertise, such as languages, science or technology), and the percentage of support for this option fell by the end of the deliberations (56.7% T1 and 50.8% T2). The drop in support for specialist schools does not mean, however, that this would be unworkable as a policy since a significant percentage of the participants (21.2% T1 and 26.7% T2) indicated that they had no strong view, neither supporting nor opposing the option. A substantive majority of parents (72.0% T1 and 65.2% T2) continued to support the idea of having a system of all-ability schools, all providing the same wide curriculum.

These results demonstrate that the vast majority of parents support retaining the current system of having both academic and technical/vocational. However, the results also demonstrate that parents support all-ability schools, all providing the same wide curriculum. One possible way of interpreting these seemingly contradictory findings is to argue that parents are mainly concerned with ensuring there are good schools for their children, but they are not quite clear, as to how this can best be achieved. The opinion of parents on the issue of specialist schools also remains unclear. But the results demonstrate that there would be no substantive parental opposition to this policy if it were to be implemented and that in fact a small majority would actually be in favour of the option. ■

Pre-deliberation (T1)



Pre-deliberation (T2)





School collaboration

The report of the Independent Strategic Review of Education suggests that in future 'cross-sectoral collaboration will be central to protecting local provision'. Participants in the Deliberative Poll were informed, therefore, that under current government proposals, it is intended that schools will collaborate with other schools to a greater extent, largely as a consequence of delivering the 'entitlement framework' but also for economic reasons. It will be largely up to schools and management interests to determine who they want collaborate with and how far they want to develop these arrangements. Following deliberation, participants were asked to indicate if they would support, oppose, or, neither support nor oppose the following choices for schools in the Omagh area:

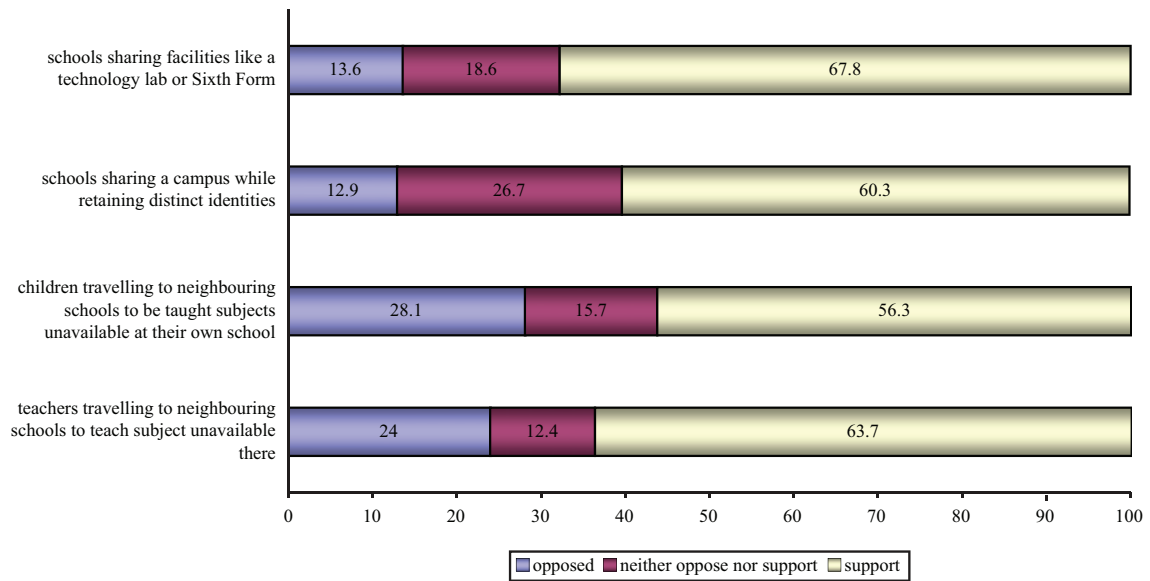
1. schools sharing facilities like a technology lab or Sixth Form
2. schools sharing a campus while retaining distinct identities
3. children travelling to neighbouring schools to be taught subjects unavailable at their own school
4. teachers travelling to neighbouring schools to teach subjects unavailable there.

A large majority of parents supported the idea of schools sharing facilities and this increased substantially by the end of the deliberations (67.8% T1 and 78.7% T2). On the question of schools sharing a campus while retaining distinct identities, a majority also indicated their support (60.3% T1 and 56.1% T2). However, the deliberative process also resulted in an increase in the number of parents opposing the option (12.9% T1 and 27.2% T2).

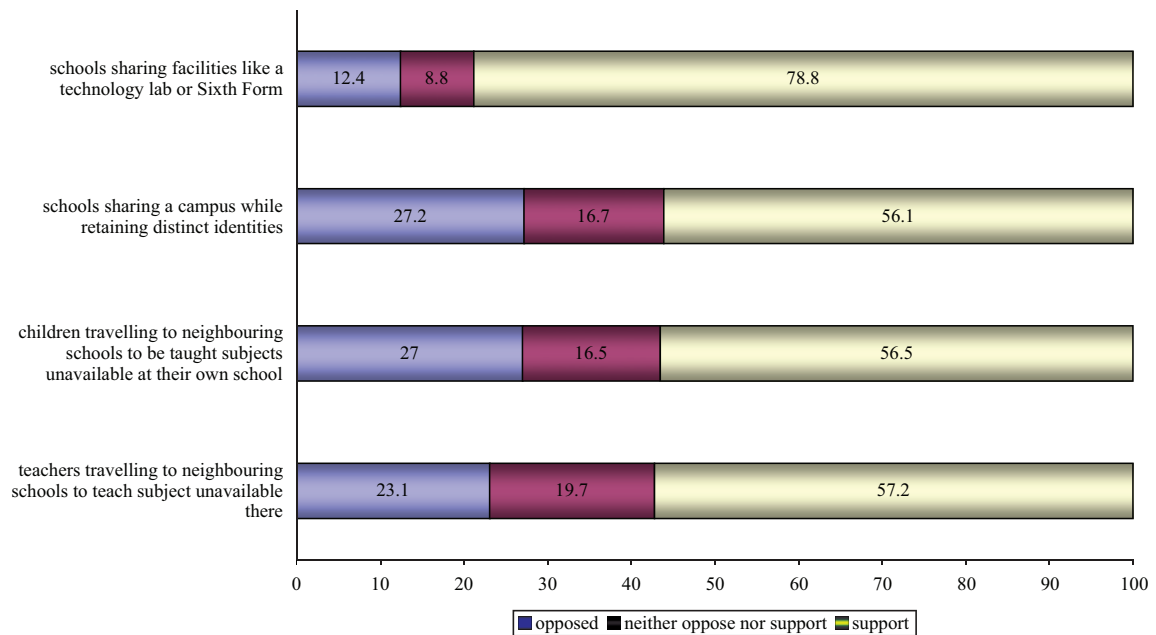
There was no substantial change in support (56.3% T1 and 56.5% T2) or opposition (28.1% T1 and 27% T2) with respect to the idea of children travelling to neighbouring schools to be taught subjects unavailable at their own school. Although only a small majority of parents favoured this option, it does not mean that it would be an unworkable policy since a significant percentage of parents (21.2% T1 and 26.7% T2) also indicated that they had no strong view either way.

The results demonstrate that parents broadly endorse the idea of school collaboration. There appears to be a preference for shared facilities over the option of children travelling to neighbouring schools. Overall, the results suggest a significant level of flexibility. The least favoured option was for schools in Omagh to share a campus while retaining distinct identities. ■

Pre-deliberation (T1)



Post-deliberation (T2)





Cross-community sharing

For many years, social attitudes surveys and public opinion polls in Northern Ireland have shown that a majority of respondents would like to send their children to, or to see an increase in the number of, mixed-religion or formally integrated schools.⁵ Despite the consistent level of support for mixing and integration, religious and community separation remains high, with less than 11% of schools (including those with formal integrated status) having more than 10% of the minority tradition within their pupil profile.⁶

The report of the Independent Strategic Review of Education notes that 'all schools, and all the educational interests, need to, and wish to, play their part in the journey towards the goal of a shared future'. Accordingly, it has been recommended that the Department of Education make clear that, in discharging its duty to encourage and facilitate integrated education, it is committed to facilitating and encouraging an inclusive strategy with a variety of meaningful approaches. The Deliberative Poll sought to find out if parents would support cross-community sharing in a situation where local children and schools might actually be affected. In particular, participants were asked whether children should attend schools only with children of the same religion or, alternatively, if children should attend schools that have a balanced enrolment of Protestant and Catholic pupils.

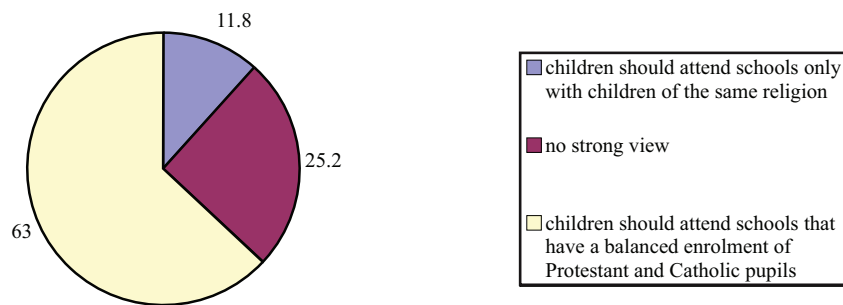
Results pre- and post-deliberation did not show significant changes in the opinions of those taking part. A majority of parents (63% T1 and 63.8% T2) believed that children should attend schools that have a balanced enrolment of Protestant and Catholic pupils, with a substantial number holding no strong view (25.2% T1 and 24.1% T2). Following on from this question, the parents who took part were asked to consider if they agreed, disagreed, or neither agreed nor disagreed with the following statements:

1. schools that are not mixed should be required to partner with a school with children of a different religion;
2. schools that need to partner to deliver the curriculum should be required to partner with their closest neighbouring school, even if it is not of the same religious composition;
3. if schools of different religious composition enter partnerships, the children from both schools should at least sometimes be taught in the same classroom. ■

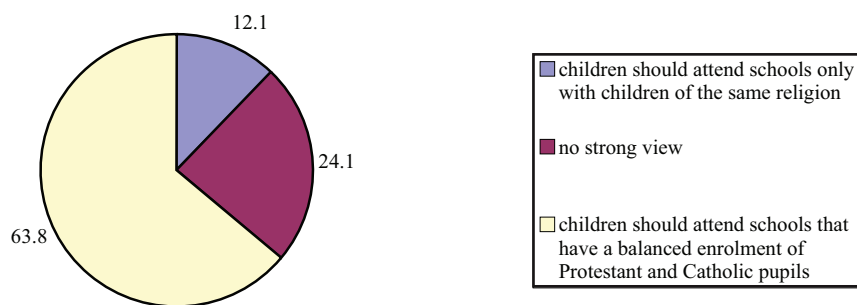
⁵ See for example, the Northern Ireland Life and Times Survey. Available at <http://www.ark.ac.uk/nilt/>

⁶ Information from Northern Ireland Schools Census, Department of Education, Statistics and Research Branch. Available at <http://www.deni.gov.uk>

Pre-deliberation (T1)



Post-deliberation (T2)

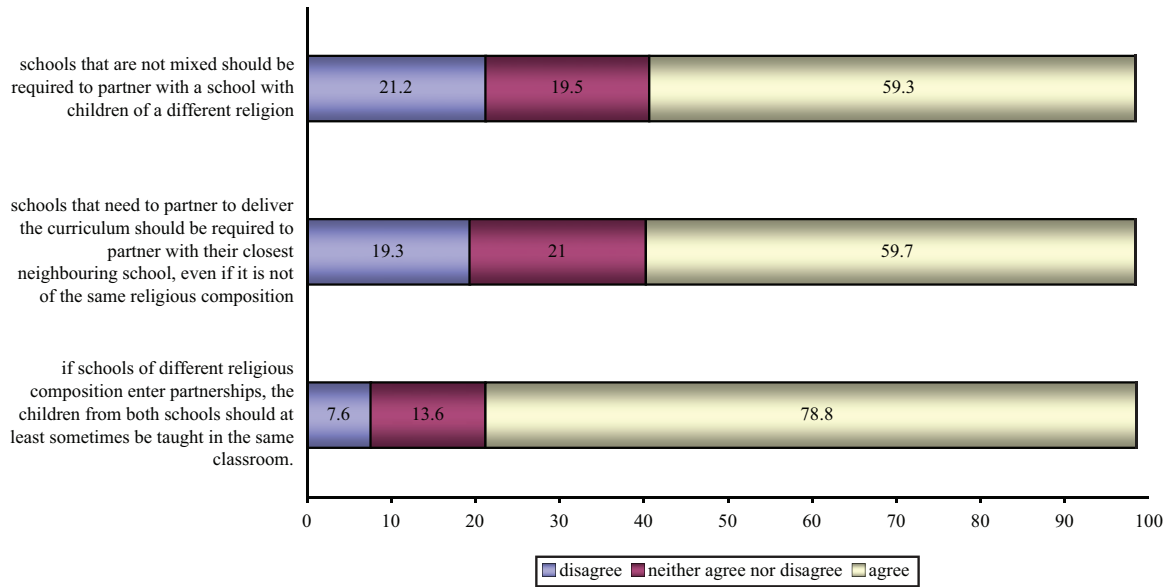




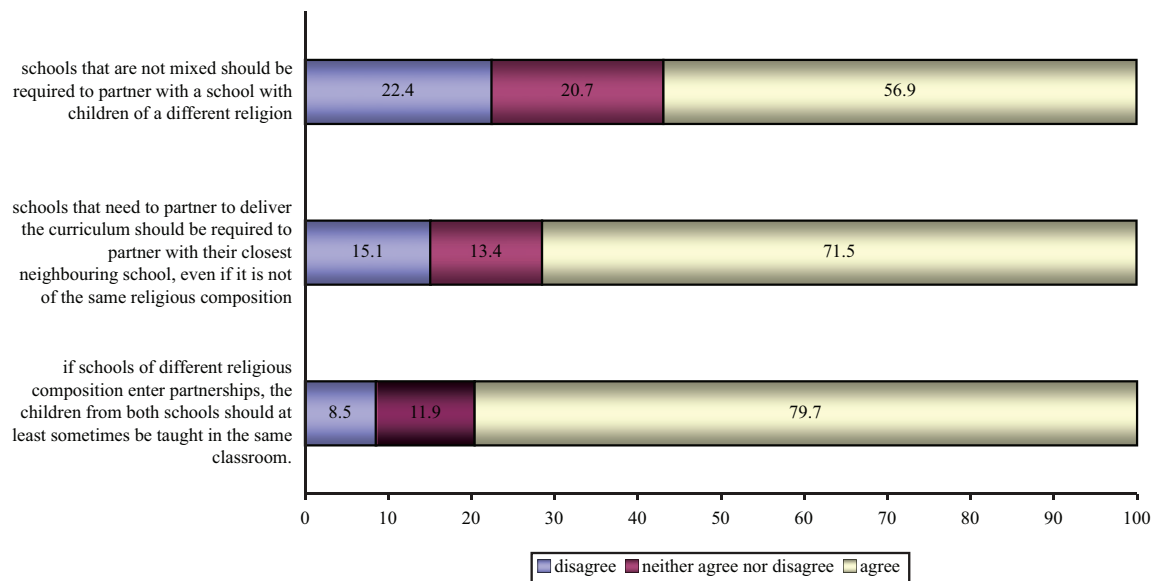
There was no significant change of opinion on the question of schools that are *not* mixed being required to partner with a school comprised of children from a different religion. A majority of participants both pre-deliberation and post-deliberation (59.3 T1 and 56.9 T2) agreed with this statement. There was significant change among parents, however, when asked to consider if schools that need to partner to deliver the curriculum should be required to partner with their closest neighbouring school, even if it is not of the same religious composition. The percentage agreeing with this statement witnessed a sharp rise (59.7 T1 and 71.5 T2). A vast majority of participants (78.8 T1 and 79.7% T2) also agreed that when schools of different religious composition enter partnerships, the children from both schools should at least sometimes be taught in the same classroom. This percentage started high pre-deliberation and remained high post-deliberation with no significant changes in opinion taking place.

The results suggest that parents would prefer their children to attend schools comprised of equal numbers of children from the two main communities. A majority also favoured the idea of schools that are not mixed being required to partner a school with children of another religion, although this option received the lowest level of support. Participants favoured ideas that were seen to have a practical benefit. In particular, this was demonstrated by those who changed their opinion following deliberation so as to support the notion of a school partnering with its closest neighbour to deliver the curriculum, even if that school is not of the same religious composition. Reflecting on the concept of what cross-community sharing would mean for partnerships, the parents clearly supported the idea that this should involve children from different schools being educated together in the same classroom. ■

Pre-deliberation (T1)



Post-deliberation (T2)





Denominational collaboration

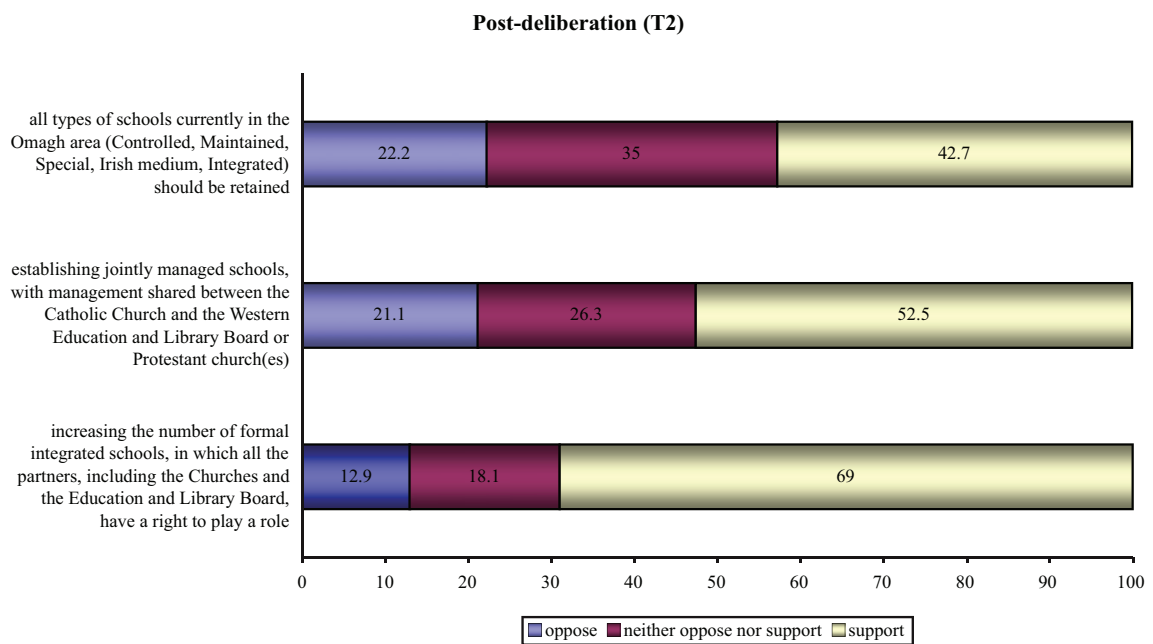
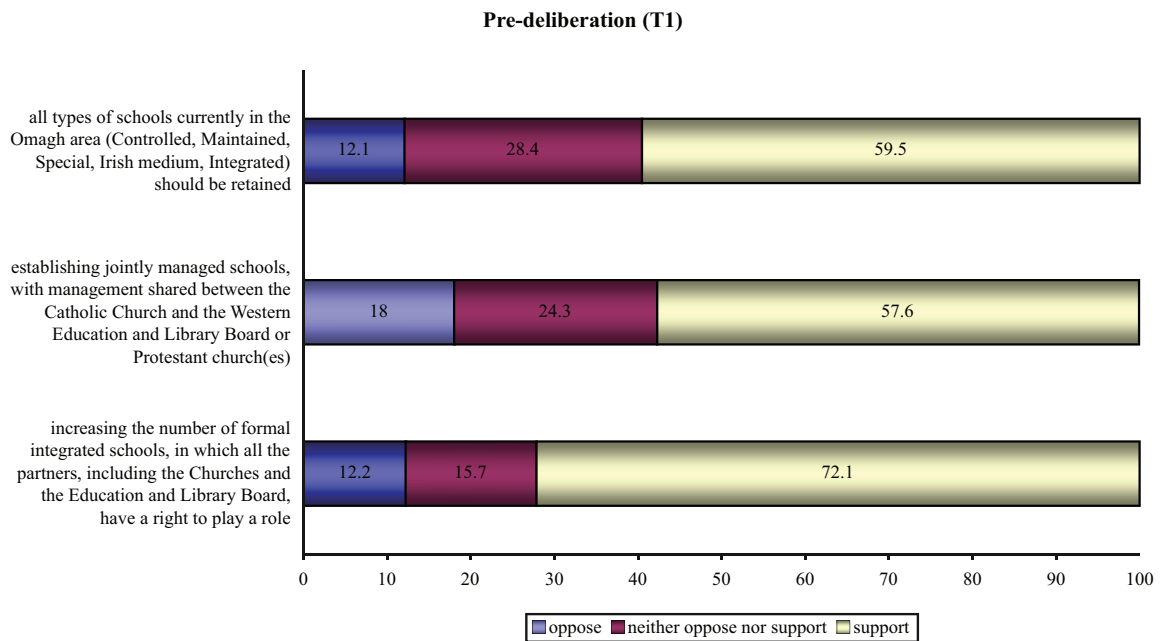
Omagh is in many ways a microcosm of the Northern Ireland education system since it contains Controlled, Voluntary, Catholic Maintained, Integrated, Irish Medium, Co-ed and Single-sex, and Grammar schools. To a greater or lesser extent these schools have active involvement by the main Christian churches in their management. Representatives of the Catholic Church sit on the Boards of Governors of Catholic schools, while the main Protestant Churches are represented on the Boards of Governors of Controlled schools. Other types of schools normally do not have any statutory representation of the Churches on their Boards of Governors. Integrated schools, Special schools and Irish Medium schools do not have any particular relationship with specific religious denominations. Participants in the Deliberative Poll were asked to reflect upon the current situation and then to indicate if they would support, oppose, or neither support nor oppose the following policy choices for schools in the Omagh area:

1. all types of schools currently in the Omagh area (Controlled, Maintained, Special, Irish medium, Integrated) should be retained;
2. establishing jointly managed schools, with management shared between the Catholic Church and the Western Education and Library Board or Protestant church(es);
3. increasing the number of formal integrated schools, in which all the partners, including the Churches and the Education and Library Board, have a right to play a role.

There were some significant changes in the opinions of parents on these options. In particular, support for retaining all types of schools currently in the Omagh area diminished post-deliberation (59.5% T1 and 42.7%). There was also an increase in the percentage of parents having no strong view on the issue either way (28.4% T1 and 35% T2). A small majority favoured establishing jointly-managed schools, although the percentage of support for this option fell by the end of the Omagh College event (57.6% T1 and 52.5% T2). The overwhelming number of parents, both pre- and post deliberation (72.1% T1 and 69% T2), supported increasing the number of formal integrated schools. While retaining all types of schools had the least opposition pre-deliberation (12.1% T1), opposition significantly increased post-deliberation (22.2% T2). This shift in opinion meant that increasing the number of formal integrated schools became the least opposed option (12.2% T1 and 12.9% T2).

The results for denominational collaboration show that parents of school-aged children are open to, and indeed favour, change. The majority do not support retaining the current system. Indeed, this option was subject to a notable drop in support, with the level of opposition (12.1% T1 and 22.2% T2) increasing following the days' discussions. This does not mean, of course, that the status quo could not remain. Indeed, combining the figures for those who neither support nor oppose retaining the current system with those who indicated support would constitute a majority. Given a choice, however, the participants clearly demonstrated a preference for increasing the number of formal integrated schools. Moreover, there is a notable percentage difference between those supporting this option and those supporting the second favoured approach, namely establishing jointly-managed schools. A majority (albeit a very small majority) would support establishing jointly-managed schools. But, once again, similar to the option of retaining the current system, the idea of jointly-managed schools witnessed a degree of change in opinion with those opposing this option increasing post-deliberation (18% T1 and 21.1% T2).







Age-grouping for schools

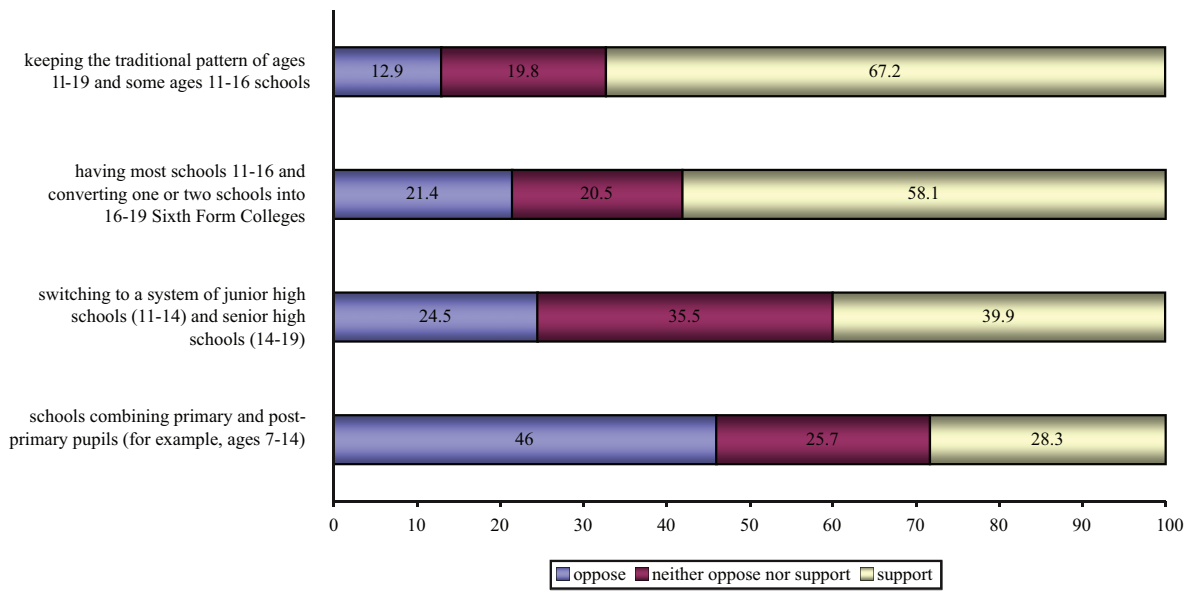
Most primary schools in Northern Ireland take pupils aged 7-11 and most post-primary schools either take pupils aged 11-16 years, or pupils aged 11-19 years. There has been much discussion, in the context of the post-primary review of education, the introduction of the Education (Northern Ireland) Order 2006 and the proposed ending of academic selection at aged eleven, as to what the appropriate age-grouping for children within a school ought to be. The Deliberative Poll sought to find out what informed parents would think about this issue. Accordingly, the participants were asked if they would support, oppose, or neither support nor oppose the following policy choices for schools in the Omagh area:

1. keeping the traditional pattern of ages 11-19 and some ages 11-16 schools;
2. having most schools 11-16 and converting one or two schools into 16-19 Sixth Form Colleges;
3. switching to a system of junior high schools (11-14) and senior high schools (14-19);
4. schools combining primary and post-primary pupils (for example, ages 7-14).

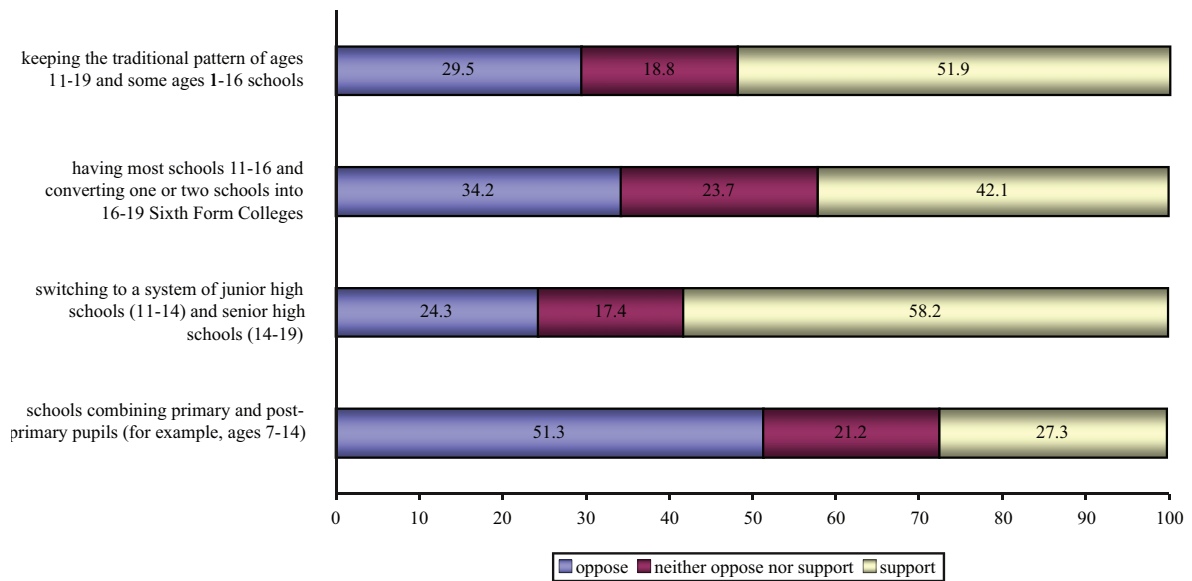
Participants were initially very supportive of keeping the traditional age pattern, but deliberation led to a significant change of opinion with support diminishing to a very small majority (67.2% T1 and 51.9% T2). The option of having most schools 11-19 and converting one or two schools into 16-19 Sixth Form Colleges followed a similar trajectory, but notably in this instance majority support pre-deliberation was not sustained post-deliberation (58.1% T1 and 42.1% T2). Also, there was a large increase in the amount of opposition to this option (21.4% T1 and 34.2%). Pre-deliberation participants were split on the idea of switching to a system of junior high schools (11-14) and senior high schools (14-19), but this witnessed a dramatic shift in opinion, with a majority supporting the option following the discussion (39.9% T1 and 58.2% T2). The notion of schools combining primary and post-primary pupils witnessed a significant rise in levels of opposition (46% T1 and 51.3% T2).

These results demonstrate significant shifts in the opinions held by the participants. Prior to deliberation keeping the traditional age pattern was by far the most supported option. Significantly, following deliberation this option was favoured less strongly than that of switching to a system of junior-high schools (11-14) and senior-high schools (14-19). Once again, the poll indicates that informed parents would prefer change. However, it also shows that there are limits to what changes are considered acceptable. For example, the percentage of parents opposing the idea of schools combining primary and post-primary pupils was significant pre-deliberation, and this percentage increased to become a majority after deliberation. It should also be noted that the level of support for having most schools 11-16 and converting one or two schools into 16-19 Sixth Form Colleges diminished as a result of deliberation, while the percentage of opposition, although not a majority, increased substantially (21.4% T1 and 34.2% T2). ■

Pre-deliberation (T1)



Pre-deliberation (T2)





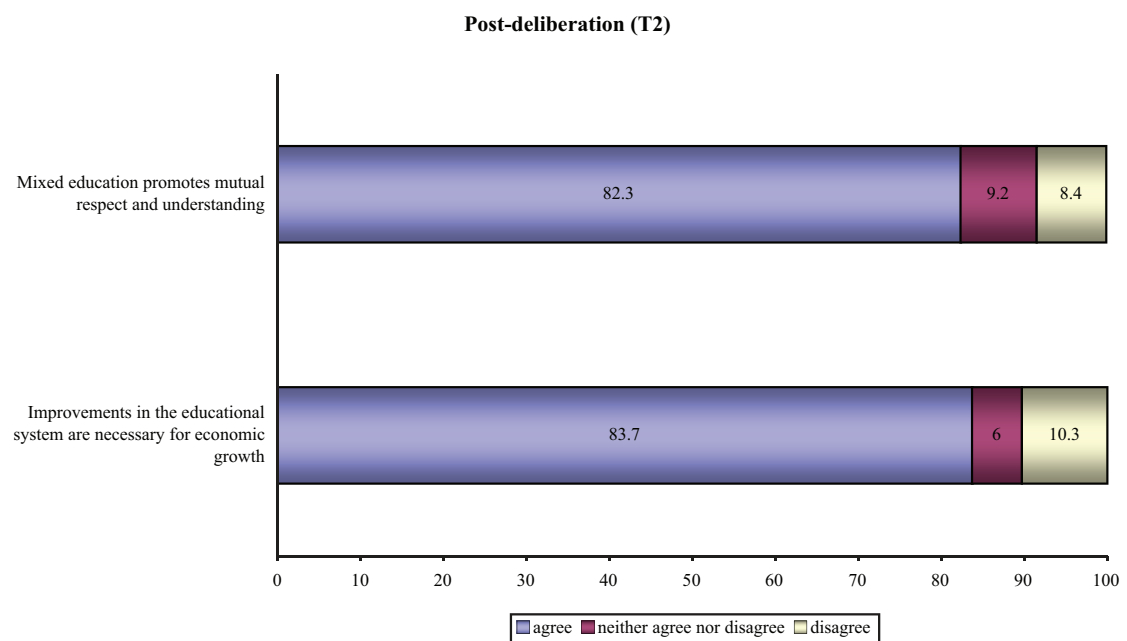
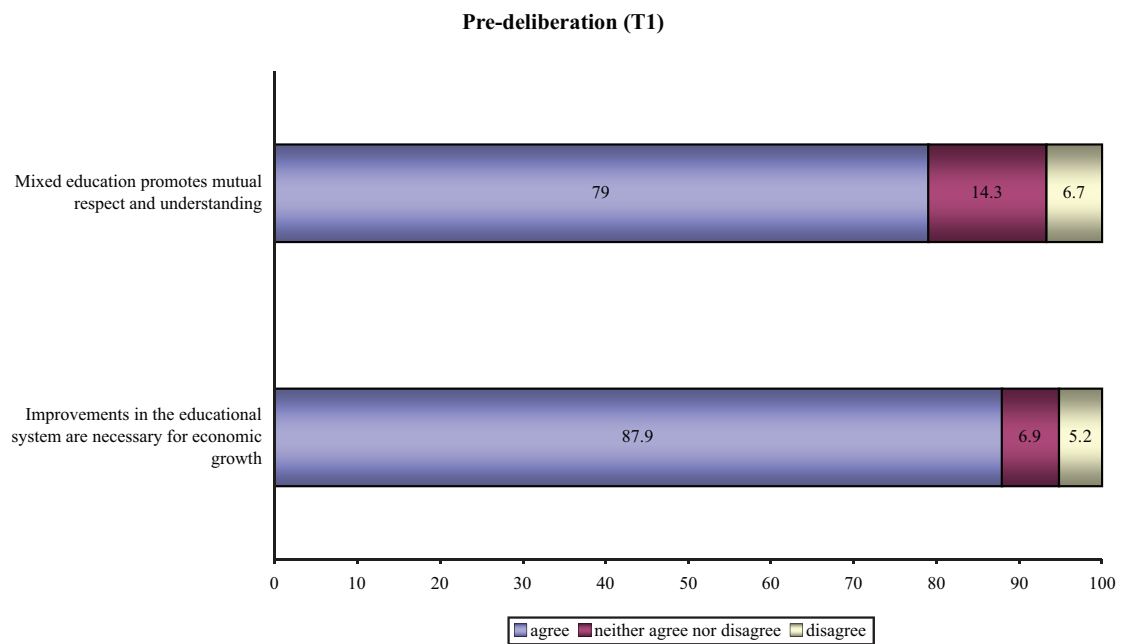
The purposes and outcomes of education

The Deliberative Poll sought to measure the perceived purposes of education and the outcomes that participants thought should result from the system. Specifically, parents who took part were asked whether they agreed, disagreed, or neither agreed nor disagreed with the following two statements:

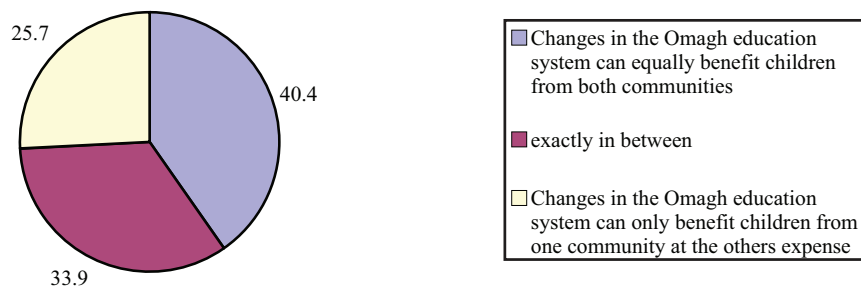
1. mixed education promotes mutual respect and understanding;
2. improvements in the educational system are necessary for economic growth.

The idea that mixed education promotes mutual respect and understanding started with a very high percentage in agreement and continued to become even higher post-deliberation (79% T1 and 82.3% T2). The level of agreement with the claim that improvements in the educational system are necessary for economic growth was subject to a slight fall following the event, but remained nonetheless extremely high (87.9% T1 and 83.7% T2). The parents were also asked to consider whether changes in the Omagh education system can equally benefit children from both communities, or, if changes can only benefit one community at the others expense. Results pre- and post-deliberation on this question witnessed significant changes in the opinions of those taking part. In particular, there was an increase in the percentage who believed that changes in the Omagh education system can equally benefit children from both communities (40.4% T1 and 50.9% T2).

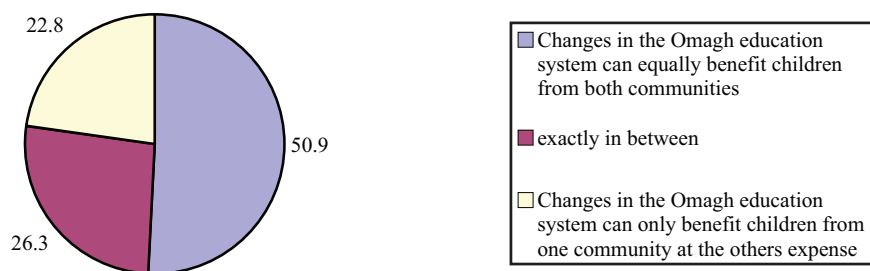
Up to this point in the poll, participants indicated willingness to, and indeed often a strong preference for, change and sharing. The same is true of this set of questions. Yet, the results seem, on the face of it, to be less definitive. One plausible interpretation is that while there is a general parental recognition that change would be positive, there is also some level of nervousness as to what reforms may actually entail in practice. The pre-deliberation tendency to disagree with the statement that changes in the Omagh education system can equally benefit children from both communities is perhaps understandable given the complexity of the issue and the historical context. Crucially, however, the fact that more parents agreed with the statement that change could be mutually beneficial at post-deliberation than at pre-deliberation shows that the discussions had brought their attitudes on this particular question more into line with their attitudes on the more general question of whether mixed education could promote mutual understanding and economic growth. ■



Pre-deliberation (T1)



Post-deliberation (T2)





Knowledge of parents

Participants in the Deliberative Poll were asked a number of factual or information-based questions. The purpose of this exercise was to determine what the parents taking part knew before and after the deliberations. The reason for asking these questions is straightforward: meaningful deliberation cannot take place in the absence of a sufficient, if indeterminate, degree of understanding of the facts. By corollary, the research team could not claim that the result of the post-deliberation questionnaire represented the informed views of parents in the absence of such questions.

Knowledge question	% of participants answering correctly at T1	% of participants answering correctly at T2
% of majority Protestant or Catholic schools with at least 10% of the other religion in their enrolment	24.0%	34.7%
% change over past 5 years in number of children entering Omagh schools	19.0%	47.1%
Entitlement framework requires: providing choice of at least 24 subjects to all 14-year-olds	20.7%	74.4%
Entitlement framework requires: that one third of all subjects offered must be applied	28.9%	62.0%
What Northern Ireland pupils do after leaving school: $\frac{3}{4}$ grammar school pupils attend university	28.1%	43.0%
Current school funding: schools receive more funding for older pupils	21.5%	78.5%
Employing authority: official employer for Voluntary Grammar teachers is Board of Governors	8.3%	9.1%

There were significant gains in knowledge. On average, the sample answered 22% of seven questions about Northern Ireland's education system correctly before deliberation but answered on average 50% correctly after deliberation. A number of questions witnessed dramatic changes. Thus, we can say with considerable authority that the opinions expressed in the post-deliberation questionnaire are those of informed parents, not only in terms of how they understand what other parents from a diverse range of backgrounds actually think as result of discussions, but also in terms of the facts which have influenced their choices. ■





Community relations

Contributing to the improvement of community relations is a significant concern for those involved in education in Northern Ireland. The Independent Strategic Review of Education acknowledged that schools have a central role to play in promoting societal well-being. Good schools are not, it is claimed, 'isolationist and inward looking but reach out to other schools in mutually beneficial relationships. The quality of those relationships, and their success in developing mutual understanding, respect, trust and tolerance, may be judged on the extent to which they involve significant, purposeful and regular engagement and interaction in learning... Children should grow up to feel comfortable in their own uniqueness, and comfortable with difference. For that to happen they need to be able to work together, and "play" together, so that eventually they can assume a shared responsibility for their future.'

The extent to which a school can successfully deliver this agenda will depend upon the support of parents. For this reason, the Deliberative Poll sought to measure parental attitudes towards community relations.

Parents were first asked a two-sided question: whether better relations between Protestants and Catholics will only come about through more mixing of the two communities, or whether better relations will only come about through more separation.

Participants became increasingly optimistic about the benefits of mixing. When asked whether better relations between Protestants and Catholics would come about as a result of 'more mixing' or of 'more separation', the parents were generally supportive of more mixing pre-deliberation, with the level of support increasing post-deliberation (61.3% T1 and 68.9% T2).

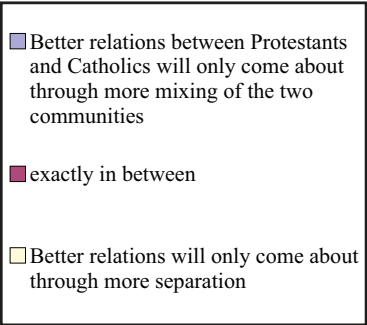
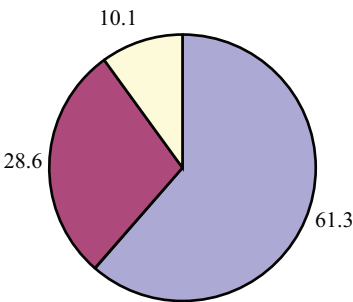
Following the question on mixing the participants were asked to consider how they viewed members from the Catholic and Protestant communities. In particular, the poll asked whether most Catholics were perceived as being open to reason, or not open to reason. It also asked whether most Protestants were perceived as being open to reason, or not open to reason.

Deliberation changed the sample's perceptions of the members of both communities, making them more positive. The percentage believing Protestants were 'open to reason' increased by 15.9% to a majority after the Omagh event (36.4% T1 and 52.3% T2). The percentage believing Catholics were 'open to reason' also increased by 15.8% to become a majority (39.8% T1 to 55.5% T2). This finding is significant not only because of the change in opinion, but also because the change was the same for both communities (within 0.1%).

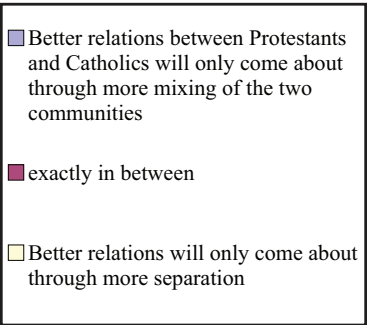
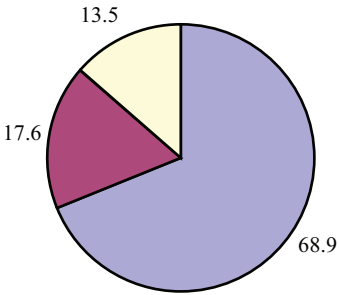
To build upon the question measuring reasonableness, participants were asked to consider perceptions of trust. In particular, the poll asked whether most Catholics are trustworthy, or untrustworthy. It also asked whether most Protestants are trustworthy, or untrustworthy.

The percentage viewing each of the two communities as 'trustworthy' increased. Perceptions of Catholics being 'trustworthy' increased by 12.9% from a minority-held view pre-deliberation to a majority-held view post-deliberation (49.5% T1 and 62.4% T2). Perceptions of Protestants being 'trustworthy' also increased by 10.4% from a minority-held view pre-deliberation to a majority-held view post-deliberation (49.9% T1 and 62.4% T2) ■

Pre-deliberation (T1)

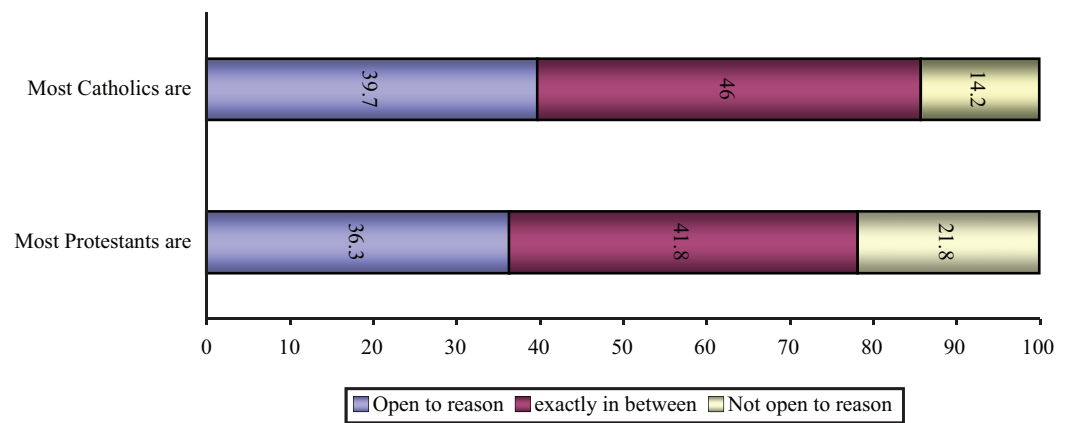


Post-deliberation (T2)

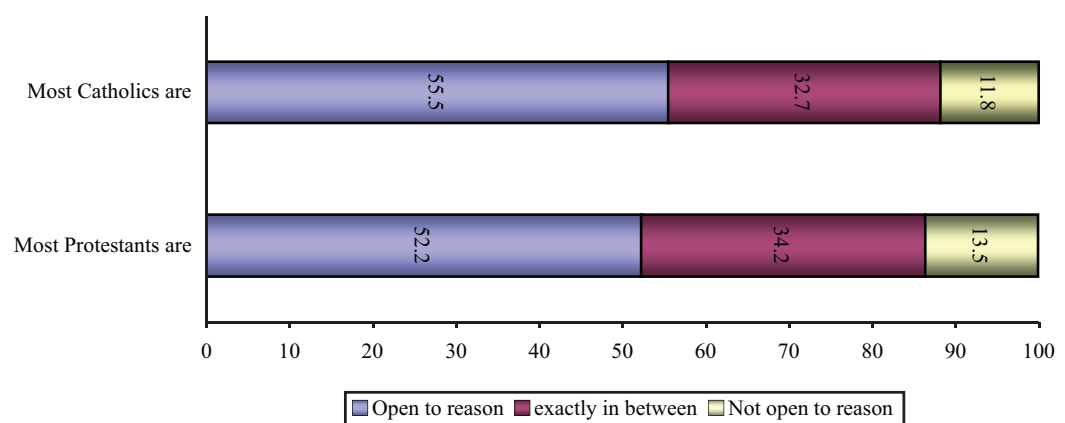


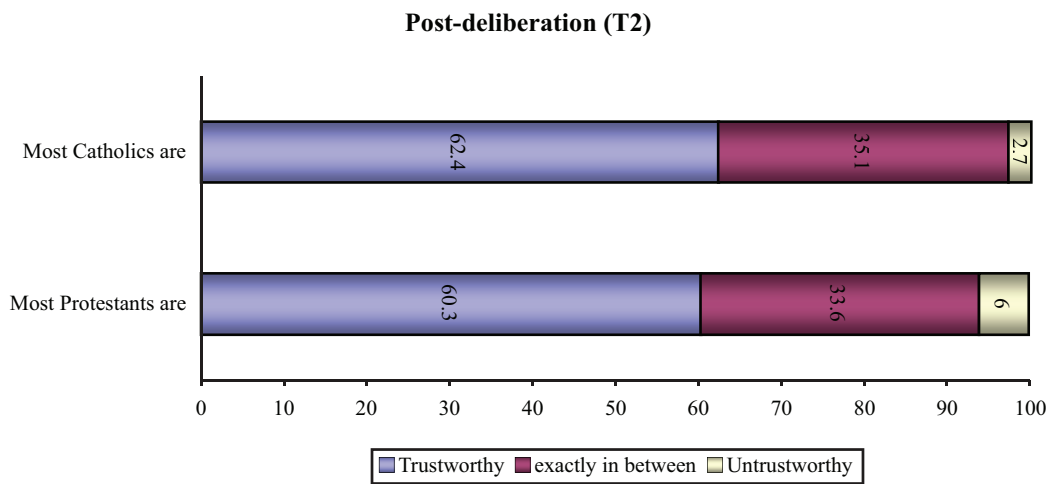
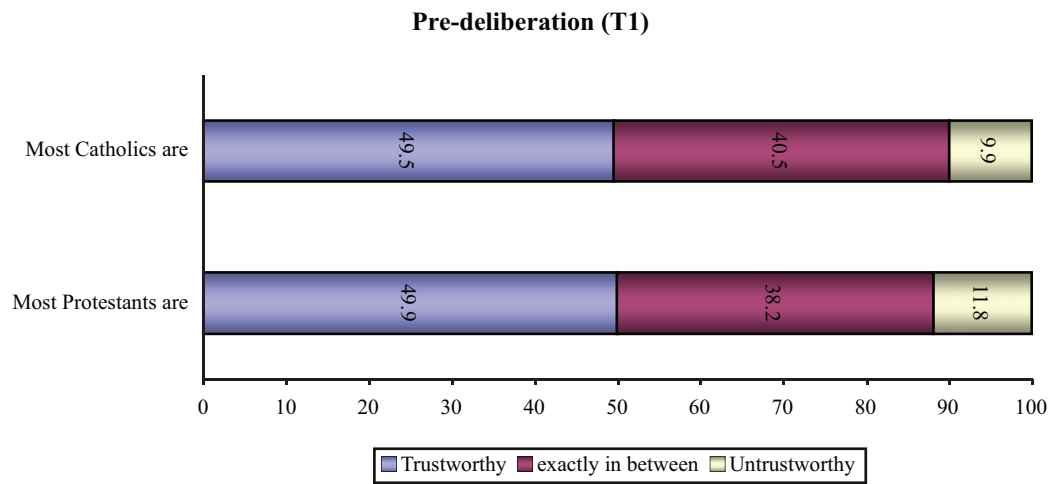


Pre-deliberation (T1)



Post-deliberation (T2)





Summary conclusions

In the context of future area-based planning, as recommended by the Independent Strategic Review of Education, the Deliberative Poll in Omagh served to demonstrate how parental opinion could be meaningfully assessed. This project has engaged key stakeholders in discussions with the parents of school-aged children in a defined geographical location in order to produce a vision of a shared educational future. The results are indicative of the provisions that informed parents would support. There are, of course, a number of areas where no definitive conclusions can be reached; these areas could be the subject of future discussions involving key stakeholders and the management interests of local schools. Crucially, however, the Deliberative Poll enables such discussions to take place in the knowledge that any policy decisions which result will themselves reflect

parental choice and a level of prior public consent.

The findings of the Deliberative Poll promote a vision of joined-up governance and the notion of a single schools' estate with a diversity of school types and various levels of functional autonomy. Informed parents are aware that change may come at a cost, but an overwhelming percentage would be willing to accept change provided it was in keeping with their general vision of the future. The Deliberative Poll has demonstrated that the concept of parental choice in Northern Ireland is unduly limited. The current education system and school types on offer fail to reflect what parents actually want. The significant knowledge gains made by those who took part in the Omagh event and the shifts in opinion seen throughout the process have raised questions on the appropriateness of current

communication and consultation methodologies, and indicate that up until the event there had been a poor level of public discourse on this issue.

In summary, the educational provision that informed parents in Omagh want is:

1. a system of good sustainable schools with the option of specialist school provision

Key stakeholders and management interests might discuss the question of how to reconcile the apparent contradiction of parental support for retaining the current system of having both academic and technical/vocational schools and the support for all-ability schools, all providing the same wide curriculum. They may also discuss the nature of specialist schools and the areas of specialisation.



2. a system that promotes meaningful school collaboration with a preference for sharing facilities, such as technology labs or Sixth Forms

Key stakeholders might discuss the ideas of children and teachers travelling to neighbouring schools to be taught or to teach subjects that are otherwise unavailable. Parents would support these options. There might also be some discussion on the option of schools sharing a campus while retaining distinct identities. However, this is the least favoured approach and would be subject to the greatest amount of opposition from parents.

3. a system in which schools proactively seek a balanced enrolment of Catholic and Protestant pupils, in which schools that need to partner to deliver the curriculum do so with their closest neighbouring school, regardless of its religious composition, and in which

children from partnering schools are taught at least some of the time in the same classroom

Key stakeholders would need to discuss what changes, if any, are needed in order for schools to seriously attempt to create a balanced enrolment of Protestant and Catholic children. Parents favour requiring schools that are not mixed to partner with a school of a different religion. However, this was the option with the least amount of support and should therefore be subject to further discussion by key stakeholders.

4. a system that witnesses a reduction in the diversity of schools types and a substantial increase in the percentage of schools that have formal integrated status with an added option of jointly managed schools.

Key stakeholders would need to discuss how an increase in the percentage of schools with formal

integrated status might take place. The support for jointly-managed schools in the poll might suggest that parents want the educational interests to consider innovative ways of delivering shared education and offer a challenge to them to consider such innovative options.

5. a system of junior high schools (11-14 years) and senior high schools (14-19)

Key stakeholders might want to further explore this option since there is support for keeping the traditional pattern of post-primary schools ages 11-16 and some 11-19. However, it should be noted that this is the less favoured approach of the two options and would also be subject to the greatest amount of opposition from parents. ■

Appendix A:
Significant pre-deliberation (T1) to post-deliberation (T2) changes among participants

The following tables detail all significant T1 to T2 opinion changes among participants
(those who attended the Deliberative Poll ® event in Omagh on January 27, 2007).

VARIABLE (scale)	T1 mean	T2 mean –	T2 mean - T1 mean (S. E.)	P (N*)
Schools sharing a campus while retaining distinct identities (0=strongly oppose; 10=strongly support)	6.78	6.01	-.773 (.329)	.02 (110)
Protestants' views: Importance for children to attend school with children of their own religion (0=own religion; 10=balanced enrolment)	4.42	5.39	.978 (.299)	.00 (89)
Own views: Changes in education system can equally benefit children from both communities (0=equally benefit both; 10=benefit one community at the other's expense)	4.28	3.45	-.827 (.360)	.02 (104)
Schools that need to partner to deliver curriculum required to partner with closest neighbouring school, even if not of same religious composition (1=strongly disagree; 5=strongly agree)	3.60	3.88	.280 (.130)	.03 (118)
Retaining all types of schools currently in the Omagh area (0=strongly oppose; 10=strongly support)	7.07	5.99	-1.08 (.324)	.00 (113)
Keeping the traditional pattern of ages 11-19 and some ages 11-16 schools (0=strongly oppose; 10=strongly support)	7.32	6.11	-1.21 (.375)	.00 (108)
Having most schools 11-16 and converting one or two schools into 16-19 Sixth Form Colleges (0=strongly oppose; 10=strongly support)	6.40	5.37	-1.03 (.348)	.00 (110)

VARIABLE (scale)	T1 mean	T2 mean –	T2 mean - T1 mean (S. E.)	P (N*)
On a scale of 0 to 10 (0=not open to reason; 10=open to reason), 5.48 where would you place - Most Protestants		6.38	.904 (.279)	.00 (104)
On a scale of 0 to 10 (0=not open to reason; 10=open to reason), 5.80 where would you place - Most Catholics		6.40	.600 (.268)	.03 (105)
On a scale of 0 to 10 (0=untrustworthy; 10=trustworthy) where would you place – Most Protestants	6.44	7.14	.694 (.253)	.01 (108)
On a scale of 0 to 10 (0=untrustworthy; 10=trustworthy) where would you place – Most Catholics	6.42	7.27	.852 (.242)	.00 (108)
Knowledge index (0=none correct; 1=all correct)	.215	.498	.283 (.021)	.00 (121)

*Only those who answered at both T1 and T2 are included in the comparison for a given issue.

Appendix B

Representativeness of event participants

The following tables compare T1 respondents who went on to participate in the Deliberative Poll in Omagh on Jan 27th, 2007 ('participants') with those who did not ('non-participants'). Significant differences ($p < 0.1$) are highlighted in yellow. P values are 2-tailed.

Numerical and binary variables

VARIABLE	Participants T1 mean (N)	(N) Non-participants T1 mean (N)	P
DEMOGRAPHICS			
Age	40.67 (121)	40.04 (436)	.43
Age when completed full-time education	17.89 (120)	17.85 (441)	.88
Number of school-age children	2.14 (121)	2.00 (444)	.17
Gender: Proportion that is female (0=male; 1=female)	.76 (121)	.69 (443)	.13
Religion: Proportion that is Catholic (0=not Catholic; 1=Catholic)	.63 (120)	.71 (432)	.11
Religion: Proportion that is Protestant (0=not Protestant; 1=Protestant)	.34 (120)	.27 (432)	.13
POLICY ITEMS			
Having both academic schools and technical/vocational schools (0=strongly oppose; 10=strongly support)	7.83 (116)	7.88 (423)	.85
Having a system of specialist schools, each developing at least one area of expertise (0=strongly oppose; 10=strongly support)	6.28 (118)	6.33 (436)	.86
Having a system of all-ability schools, all providing the same wide curriculum (0=strongly oppose; 10=strongly support)	7.31 (118)	7.12 (435)	.56
Schools sharing facilities like a technology lab or a Sixth Form (0=strongly oppose; 10=strongly support)	7.23 (118)	7.34 (432)	.71
Schools sharing a campus while retaining distinct identities (0=strongly oppose; 10=strongly support)	6.78 (116)	6.49 (426)	.35

VARIABLE	Participants T1 mean (N)	(N) Non-participants T1 mean (N)	P
Children travelling to neighbouring schools to be taught subjects unavailable at their own school (0=strongly oppose; 10=strongly support)	6.19 (121)	5.91 (435)	.44
Teachers travelling to neighbouring schools to teach subjects unavailable there (0=strongly oppose; 10=strongly support)	6.61 (121)	6.28 (434)	.35
Own views: Importance for children to attend school with children of their own religion (0=own religion; 10=balanced enrolment)	7.33 (119)	6.78 (434)	.09
Protestants' views: Importance for children to attend school with children of their own religion (0=own religion; 10=balanced enrolment)	4.39 (103)	4.68 (345)	.31
Catholics' views: Importance for children to attend school with children of their own religion (0=own religion; 10=balanced enrolment)	4.90 (107)	4.77 (358)	.66
Own views: Changes in education system can equally benefit children from both communities (0=equally benefit both; 10=benefit one community at the other's expense)	4.18 (109)	4.19 (405)	.98
Protestants' views: Changes in education system can equally benefit children from both communities (0=equally benefit both; 10=benefit one community at the other's expense)	4.80 (93)	4.71 (322)	.77
Catholics' views: Changes in education system can equally benefit children from both communities (0=equally benefit both; 10=benefit one community at the other's expense)	4.85 (95)	4.57 (331)	.31
Schools that are not mixed required to partner with a school with children of a different religion (1=strongly disagree; 5=strongly agree)	3.64 (118)	3.34 (427)	.02

VARIABLE	Participants T1 mean (N)	(N) Non-participants T1 mean (N)	P
Schools that need to partner to deliver curriculum required to partner with closest neighbouring school, even if not of same religious composition (1=strongly disagree; 5=strongly agree)	3.61 (119)	3.55 (420)	.62
If schools of different religious composition enter partnerships, children from both schools should at least sometimes be taught in the same classroom (1=strongly disagree; 5=strongly agree)	4.09 (118)	3.93 (425)	.12
Retaining all types of schools currently in the Omagh area (0=strongly oppose; 10=strongly support)	7.06 (116)	7.08 (419)	.94
Establishing jointly managed schools, with management shared between the Catholic Church and the Western Education and Library Board or Protestant church(es) (0=strongly oppose; 10=strongly support)	6.59 (111)	6.08 (410)	.11
Increasing the number of formal Integrated schools, in which all the partners, including the Churches and the Education and Library Board, have a right to play a role (0=strongly oppose; 10=strongly support)	7.44 (115)	6.43 (423)	.00
Keeping the traditional pattern of ages 11-19 and some ages 11-16 schools (0=strongly oppose; 10=strongly support)	7.30 (116)	7.51 (420)	.47
Having most schools 11-16 and converting one or two schools into 16-19 Sixth Form Colleges (0=strongly oppose; 10=strongly support)	6.36 (117)	6.28 (416)	.80
Switching to a system of junior high schools (11-14) and senior high schools (14-19) (0=strongly oppose; 10=strongly support)	5.75 (110)	4.96 (401)	.02

VARIABLE	Participants T1 mean (N)	(N) Non-participants T1 mean (N)	P
Schools combining primary and post-primary pupils (for example, ages 7-14) (0=strongly oppose; 10=strongly support)	4.35 (113)	3.64 (405)	.04
How favourably or unfavourably do you feel about Protestants (0=unfavourably; 10=favourably)	7.44 (116)	7.49 (395)	.85
How favourably or unfavourably do you feel about Catholics (0=unfavourably; 10=favourably)	7.42 (114)	7.61 (394)	.45
Own views: Better relations between Protestants and Catholics will only come about through more mixing of the two communities (0=more mixing, 10=more separation)	2.78 (119)	3.01 (420)	.45
Protestants' views: Better relations between Protestants and Catholics will only come about through more mixing of the two communities (0=more mixing, 10=more separation)	4.97 (102)	4.66 (341)	.24
Catholics' views: Better relations between Protestants and Catholics will only come about through more mixing of the two communities (0=more mixing, 10=more separation)	4.80 (104)	4.55 (356)	.33
On a scale of 0 to 10 (0=not open to reason; 10=open to reason), where would you place - Most Protestants	5.55 (110)	5.81 (371)	.34
On a scale of 0 to 10 (0=not open to reason; 10=open to reason), where would you place - Most Catholics	5.81 (113)	6.09 (379)	.26
On a scale of 0 to 10 (0=untrustworthy; 10=trustworthy) where would you place – Most Protestants	6.35 (110)	6.35 (359)	.98
On a scale of 0 to 10 (0=untrustworthy; 10=trustworthy) where would you place – Most Catholics	6.39 (111)	6.44 (360)	.81

VARIABLE	Participants T1 mean (N)	(N) Non-participants T1 mean (N)	P
Mixed education promotes mutual respect and understanding (1=strongly disagree; 5=strongly agree)	4.20 (119)	4.15 (421)	.61
Improvements in the educational system are necessary for economic growth (1=strongly disagree; 5=strongly agree)	4.42 (116)	4.33 (115)	.28
Knowledge index (mean proportion of answers correct)	.215 (121)	.203 (444)	.57

Categorical variables

VARIABLE	Participants T1 percentages (N)	Non-participants T1 percentages (N)	Z, P
Demographics			
<i>Marital status</i>			
Single (never married)	10.7% (13)	10.8% (48)	6.73, .24
Married	66.9% (81)	74.3% (329)	
Living as married	7.4% (9)	2.9% (13)	
Separated	9.1% (11)	6.5% (29)	
Divorced	4.1% (5)	4.3% (19)	
Widowed	1.7% (2)	1.1% (5)	
<i>Employment status</i>			
Working full-time	38.0% (46)	42.6% (189)	12.62, .25
Working part-time	19.8% (24)	16.2% (72)	
Not working (seeking work)	1.7% (2)	2.9% (13)	
On a government training scheme	0% (0)	0.2% (1)	
Retired	2.5% (3)	1.1% (5)	
In full-time education	0.8% (1)	0.2% (1)	
Looking after the home	31.4% (38)	27.9% (124)	
Permanently sick or disabled	0% (0)	2.0% (9)	
Not working (and not seeking work)	5.8% (7)	3.4% (15)	
Caring for an elderly/disabled person full-time	0% (0)	1.4% (6)	
Other	0% (0)	2.0% (9)	
<i>Highest educational qualification</i>			
Degree level or higher	19.2% (23)	18.8% (83)	3.68, .82
BTEC/BEC/TEC (higher), HNC, HND	2.5% (3)	5.2% (23)	
GCE A-level (incl. NVQ level 3)	13.3% (16)	10.2% (45)	
BTEC/TEC (national), ONC, OND	4.2% (5)	2.5% (11)	6.1% (27)
GCSE (incl. NVQ level 2), GCE O-level	27.5% (33)	27.4% (121)	
CSE (other than grade 1)		5.0% (6)	
No formal qualification	21.7% (26)	21.8% (96)	
Other	6.7% (8)	7.9% (35)	
<i>Religion</i>			
Catholic	63.3% (76)	71.3% (308)	2.82, .24
Protestant	34.2% (41)	26.9% (116)	
Other	2.5% (3)	1.9% (8)	
<i>Political affiliation</i>			
Unionist	16.0% (19)	11.2% (47)	2.24, .52
Nationalist	26.1% (31)	27.1% (114)	
Neither	57.1% (68)	61.2% (257)	
Other	0.8% (1)	0.5% (2)	

The Deliberative Poll was led by Newcastle University in collaboration with the School of Education, Queen's University Belfast and the Centre for Deliberative Democracy, Stanford University.



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